

heavy vehicles. But by July 2006 his wife had become the owner of four dumpers with an address registered in Jaypee Nagar, Rewa. Chauhan has denied the allegations of disproportionate assets saying that the trucks were financed. But when former Union minister and Bharati aide Prahlad Patel demanded an explanation about the dumpers, the details were erased from the Transport Department's website.

The complaints refer to the vehicles being bought with guarantees from cement company JP Associates, Rewa and, after the matter came to light, being transferred back to the same company. Even Patel has admitted that they were unable to provide

tified under the Minerals Concession Rules. While the Congress complaint has similar allegations about a number of other projects (see box), it has provided documentary evidence only of the favours shown to JP Associates.

A day after the FIR was registered, Chauhan went into a huddle with his legal team led by senior counsel Shantilal Lodha and he was assured that the case against him was not strong enough. While Chauhan plans to field a team of high-profile legal luminaries to get the FIR quashed, BJP has launched a counter-offensive against the Congress. "Those who occupied high offices during the Congress regime have numerous cases pending

confidence of sailing through the crisis stems from the party's backing at the state and central levels. Party veteran and Chauhan's mentor Sunderlal Patwa has questioned the alacrity with which the Lokayukta, Justice (retd) Ripusudan Dayal, a Congress appointee had registered an FIR when the court had only called for an inquiry and a status report. The ruling party has also attributed motives to the actions of the ombudsman in various cases including the ongoing tiff with Speaker Ishwardas Rohani who recently issued a breach of privilege notice to the Lokayukta for registering cases against Vidhan Sabha Secretariat officials without the



CORNERED: Chauhan is optimistic that he will emerge unscathed

evidence of favours granted to the company. But the Congress complaint says that Chauhan's payback to JP Associates was in the form of a favour by the secretary, Department of Mines and Minerals, who revoked a decision taken on June 22, 1995 to grant prospecting licence of mining to Dalmia Cement (Bharat) Ltd, Delhi for a 1,435-hectare area in Satna through two separate orders on February 15 and March 23, 2007. This prospecting licence was in turn given to JP Associates even before Dalmia Cement's licence was cancelled or no-

DUMPED BUT NOT OUT

CHARGE: Prospecting lease for limestone mining on 1,435 hectare granted to Dalmia Cement on June 22, 1995 but withdrawn on February 15, 2007 and given to JP Associates on March 23, 2007 in violation of rules.

CHAUHAN'S REPLY: Was uninvolved and did not issue any verbal or written orders. Routine matter handled by department.

CHARGE: Illegal favours to JP Associates in Hinoti limestone mining project (Satna), new captive Budgawana mines (Sidhi), Beladev Mjow Daldal limestone mines (Satna), Nav Basta limestone mine (Rewa), JP limestone project (Rewa), Aggona limestone mine project (Sidhi) and Amilia coal mining project (Sidhi).

CHAUHAN'S REPLY: Wild allegations without any documentary evidence. Congress gave mining lease to JP Cement on 470 hectare area in seven villages for the period 1984-2004. Collector Rewa gave 5 hectare land to JP Associates for access road to mining land in June 2005 when Chauhan was not CM.

against them in various courts and anti-corruption agencies," says state BJP chief Narendra Singh Tomar. The party believes it will emerge a winner in the debate on corruption simply because the Congress government was embroiled in far more serious scams—like the Rs 714 crore inter-corporate deposit scam. BJP has pointed out that the same company, JP Associates, had been given far bigger land leases during the Congress regime. Tomar adds, "The Congress had granted a 470-hectare mining lease in seven villages for the period 1984-2004 which should also be counted as a scam."

After the initial jitters, Chauhan's

Speaker's consent.

The Congress has planned its moves carefully. A day after the Lokayukta SPE registered the FIR, the complainant filed a caveat in the Jabalpur High Court to prevent one-sided hearings into any appeal by Chauhan or quashing of the FIR. Besides, the Congress has revived its old tactic of personality-based politics, which was used effectively against Bharati over cutting of the cake on Hanuman Jayanti.

But time seems to favour Chauhan. BJP, not too keen for another replacement after Bharati and Babulal Gaur, particularly with state elections only a year ahead, hardly has any young OBC leader who can take charge. And when it comes to image, Chauhan is still cleaner than most hopefuls in the state. For the moment it seems, he is on a safe wicket. ■



"It is for the first time that a chief minister and his wife are together facing serious graft charges."

DIGVIJAY SINGH, FORMER CHIEF MINISTER